FIELD GUIDE

Observed in their natural habitat:
the session replay

'WILD USERS'

FIRST EDITION

COMPILED BY
POSTHOG



BOOK ONE

THIS GUIDE BELONGS TO:

_____

For the engineers, designers, and product managers who suspected these creatures existed but could never quite prove it.

© PostHog, 2026.

All species observed under the watchful eye of Replay Vision.
Latin binomials of the author's own coinage; legitimacy contested.

WILD USERS

FIRST EDITION

Observed in their natural habitat:
the session replay

OBSERVED AND CATALOGED BY

Sir Bartholomew Hogworth, F.R.S.

PostHog

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FOREWORD FROM THE NATURALIST

There is a particular kind of patience required to watch users. In my early years of fieldwork, before any of this was possible I would sit at the edge of a single session recording and wait. Most yielded nothing. A handful would reveal something so quietly remarkable that it justified the previous forty hours of nothing in particular. The rate of discovery is, by tradition, slow.

Well, it is no longer slow.

Until the nice people of PostHog made Replay Vision (https://posthog.com/replay-vision). Replay Vision watches every session on a schedule that does not require my presence. It prioritizes the problems worth surfacing, and it brings the findings to whoever is meant to receive them. The species are still out there in the field, behaving as they always have. They are simply being cataloged without me. I no longer wade through the field; I only read the field notes that come back and make decisions about the next step.

This is, in essence, the same shift that has overtaken the motorcar, now applied to software. The product self-drives, while the human reads the road ahead and decides what direction to take.

The species cataloged here are the ones we have observed often enough to name. There are more, almost certainly living in your product right now. Replay Vision is still watching. The field guide that follows is, in effect, a list of things you no longer have to look for yourself. Your job is to decide what to do about the Rage-Clicker.

— Sir Bartholomew Hogworth, F.R.S. First Edition, 2026

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

Each species in this guide follows the same structure, which has been refined over many years of fieldwork and one or two arguments at the Royal Society dinner. The structure is as follows:

APPEARANCE	Visible characteristics, behavioral tells, and any features by which the species may be reliably identified in the field.
HABITAT	The regions of a product where the species is most often encountered.
FIELD NOTES	A narrative description of the species at work, drawn from many hundreds of observed sessions. The naturalist's opinions are kept out wherever possible.
RESOLUTION	How the session ends for this species, whether that is conversion, abandonment, a support ticket, or a quiet return days later.
HAZARDS OBSERVED	Environmental factors that appear to provoke or accelerate the species' defining behavior. Sometimes, under the reader's control.
CONSERVATION STATUS	A short and informal assessment of the species' standing in the modern product.
IF YOU SPOT ONE	Practical guidance for catching the species yourself, using Replay Vision. Each entry names a specific scanner type (monitor, classifier, indexer, or summariser) and the prompt or filter that will surface the species in your own product.

The species are presented in no particular order. They are not ranked by frequency, importance, or severity, on the principle that a field naturalist's job is to only observe what is there without judgement.

The guide may be read cover to cover or kept by the desk and consulted whenever a session begins to behave in ways the reader does not immediately recognize. The Latin binomials are of the author's own composition. Their academic legitimacy is at your own interpretation.

– S.B.H.

THE SPECIES

WILD USERS

Plate I

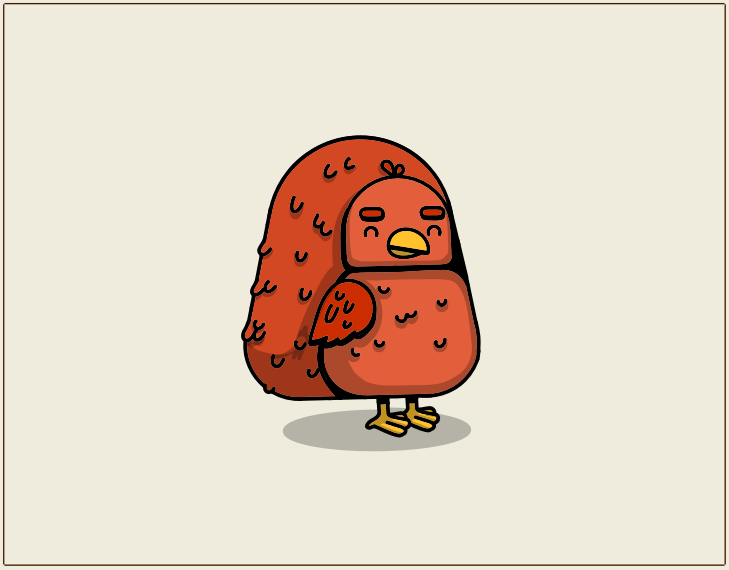
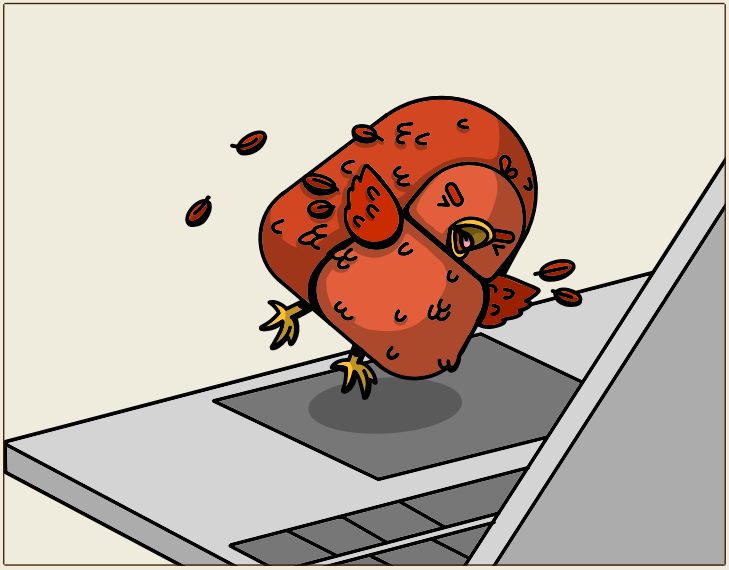


Plate II



THE RAGE-CLICKER

Furiosus checkoutus

APPEARANCE

Distinguished by rapid, repetitive tapping of the beak on a single point. Plumage darkens visibly toward the tail end of the encounter. Often accompanied by an audible exhale (inaudible to the scanner, but inferable from typing cadence).

HABITAT

Payment forms, "Submit" buttons, modal dialogs that have already been dismissed once. Rarely found in onboarding flows, almost always near the moment of intended conversion.

FIELD NOTES

The Rage-Clicker arrives at a payment form with clear intent. It attempts to proceed. Nothing happens. It attempts to proceed again. Nothing happens. The seventh attempt is indistinguishable from the first to a casual observer, but Replay Vision has been keeping count.

RESOLUTION

Typically, abandonment. Occasionally, success, when the button finally responds and the user proceeds, visibly suspicious that something else will break. A small percentage convert anyway.

HAZARDS OBSERVED

Disabled submit button with no error state. JavaScript error in the form-validation library. Stripe webhook hanging. Sometimes a 2-second response time you have stopped noticing.

CONSERVATION STATUS

Vulnerable. Without intervention, will not return.

IF YOU SPOT ONE

Rage clicks usually mean the button gave no response, not that the backend broke. The click registers, but nothing spins, nothing disables, and no error appears, so the user tries again. Throttle your network and hit Submit on your own checkout. If a second passes with nothing on screen, you have found what the Rage-Clicker found. A Scorer scanner rates every session 0 to 10 for frustration, so filter it to checkout, alert on the average, and send it to whoever owns the flow.

Plate I



Plate II



THE REFRESHING PILGRIM

Reloadus Hopefulus

APPEARANCE

Easily mistaken for any other user, until the right foot begins its small devotional motion toward the F5 key. The eyes carry an expression somewhere between patience and betrayal.

HABITAT

Slow-loading dashboards, third-party widgets, anything behind a status page that has not yet updated.

FIELD NOTES

The Refreshing Pilgrim does not believe the page is broken. It believes the page is merely tired, and that another reload will rouse it. One Pilgrim hit reload 14 times on a single 504 in under a minute. Faith, it would seem, is a renewable resource.

RESOLUTION

Either the page eventually loads, validating the Pilgrim's worldview, or it does not, at which point the Pilgrim abandons silently and without complaint. Rarely files a support ticket. Believes it must have been their internet, which puts the internet provider in a worse position than yourself.

HAZARDS OBSERVED

A backend timeout your team has stopped noticing. An over-eager loading spinner that resolves visually before the data arrives.

CONSERVATION STATUS

Exhausted. Might abandon the page any time now.

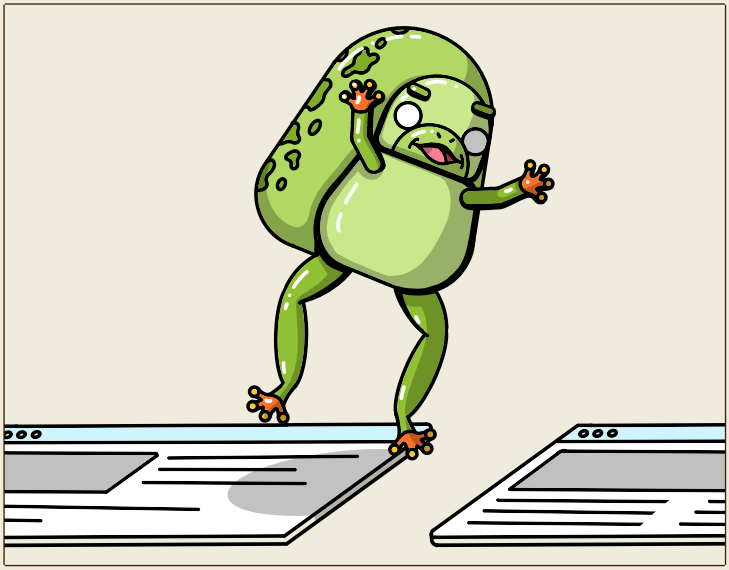
IF YOU SPOT ONE

A user who reloads the same page four times thinks it is stuck rather than broken, and they are usually right. Behind it sits a slow endpoint, or a spinner that finishes before the data lands. They will not file a ticket, so nobody on your team hears about it. A Monitor scanner flags any session that reloaded one URL three or more times, and the reload timestamp points straight at the endpoint.

Plate I



Plate II



THE TAB-HOPPER

Multitabus distractus

APPEARANCE

Integument difficult to identify. The Tab-Hopper is rarely viewed in full, only in glimpses, between other tabs. Often spotted with five open instances of your product.

HABITAT

Multi-account setups. Anywhere comparison is required. The Tab-Hopper is also frequently observed in the wild on Slack, Linear, and three different documentation sites simultaneously.

FIELD NOTES

The Tab-Hopper arrives intending to complete a task. It opens a second tab to verify a detail. It opens a third tab to consult a doc. The third tab contains a link that leads to a fourth. By the time the fifth tab opens, the Tab-Hopper has forgotten why the first tab was opened, and is thinking about something completely different.

RESOLUTION

The Tab-Hopper returns to the first tab three days later. Maybe even three weeks later. Sometimes The Hopper finishes the task. Other times, it opens a sixth tab and repeats the same process from the start. Many, many times.

HAZARDS OBSERVED

No single failure to blame. The product worked. The user has the attention span of a fruit fly on espresso, and your product is one of seven things asking for it.

CONSERVATION STATUS

Common. Possibly thriving. Hard to catch and measure.

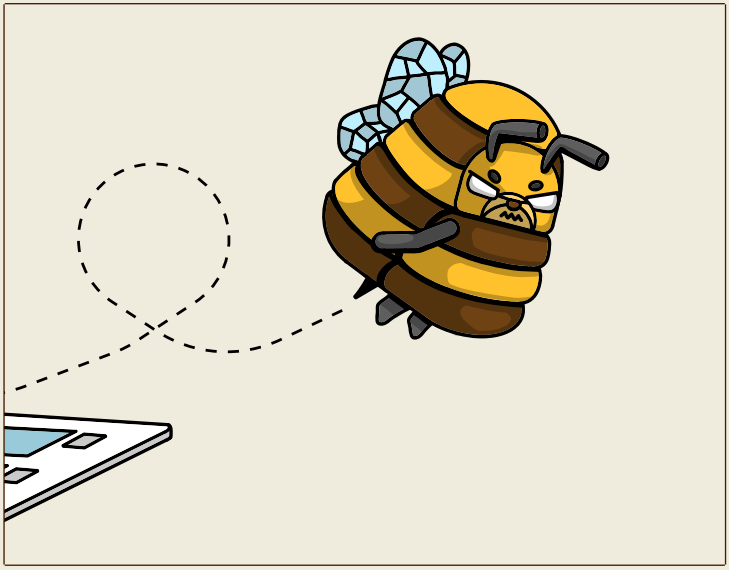
IF YOU SPOT ONE

Tab-switching is not a defect in your product, so do not try to fix the switching. The signal worth having is the task they started and left. Replay Vision trims idle time out of each recording and a tab switch is idle time, so the hop never appears on camera. The abandoned task does. Run a Monitor scanner for it, save those users as a cohort, and give them a reason to come back with an in-app nudge or an email.

Plate I



Plate II



THE MID-FORM FLEER

Abandonus formularis

APPEARANCE

Caught mid-flight, always. Wings spread, body angled away from the screen. Has typically completed 60–70% of a form before the decision to leave.

HABITAT

Signup flows. Checkout forms. Anywhere a credit-card field appears later than expected. The Mid-Form Fleer has a marked preference for the second-to-last field of any multi-step form.

FIELD NOTES

The Mid-Form Fleer arrives in good faith. It completes name, email, and company. Then it encounters something it did not expect: a "How did you hear about us?" dropdown with no fitting option, a phone-number field marked required, a CAPTCHA. And, it's gone.

RESOLUTION

Almost never returns to complete the original form. Occasionally returns to a different form on the same product, days later, as if the original encounter never happened. You probably won't even recognize it if it does.

HAZARDS OBSERVED

Required fields are perceived as intrusive. Unexpected friction at the conversion moment. A field-validation error that resets all prior entries. The discovery, mid-form, that a credit card will be required.

CONSERVATION STATUS

Endangered, if you count signups or payments. Thriving, if you don't.

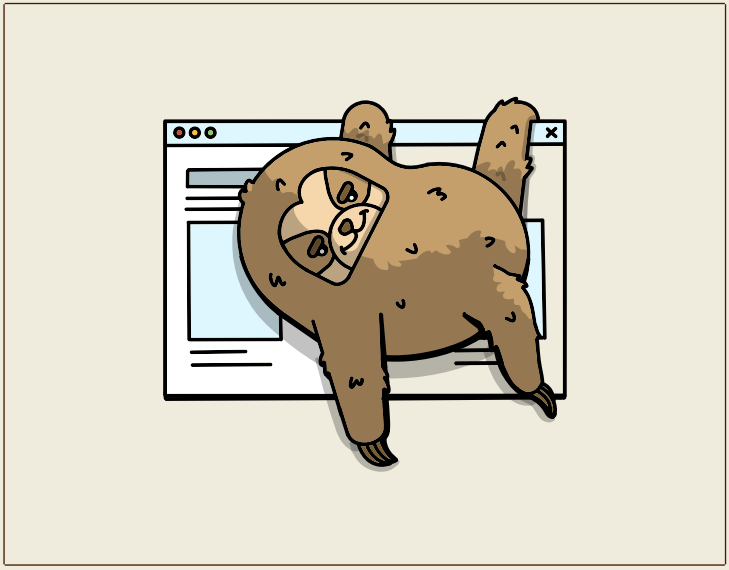
IF YOU SPOT ONE

Form abandonment comes down to one field far more often than to the length of the form, and it tends to be the field nobody on the team wanted to add: a required phone number, a CAPTCHA, or a dropdown with no option that fits. Fill in your own signup and notice where you would hesitate. A Classifier scanner asked which field the user was on when they quit tags each abandoned session with the culprit, and sorting those tags by frequency ranks your worst offenders.

Plate I



Plate II



THE PRICING-PAGE LOITERER

Pricingus revisitus

APPEARANCE

A low, settled posture, belly to the ground. Often spotted from behind, head slightly tilted, scrolling slowly between plan tiers. Eyes fixed, looking for numbers. May have a calculator tab open in the periphery.

HABITAT

Pricing page. Has been seen returning to the same pricing page across multiple devices and several months without ever signing up. Grazes the competitors' pricing pages in the same season.

FIELD NOTES

The Pricing-Page Loiterer is typically busy doing math. The math is not mathing, but it has not yet led to a strong "no" – only to "not yet." One Loiterer compared the pricing to three competitors in one session, left, and returned four days later to do it again.

RESOLUTION

Either eventually converts, usually after a price change, a new tier, or a personal budget cycle, or it goes silent forever.

HAZARDS OBSERVED

Pricing that requires too much arithmetic. A feature comparison that does not answer the question they actually have. A "Contact us" button where they expected a price. A free tier whose limits are described in units the visitor does not understand.

CONSERVATION STATUS

Cautious. Easily startled by aggressive sales follow-up.

IF YOU SPOT ONE

Somebody who visits your pricing page four times without signing up did not get an answer to one specific question, and it is nearly always what this will cost at their size. Try working out your own bill from your pricing page in under a minute. A Classifier scanner asking which tier or feature the visitor kept returning to turns that into a cohort, and sales can open with the tier the Loiterer was stuck on instead of a cold check-in.

Plate I

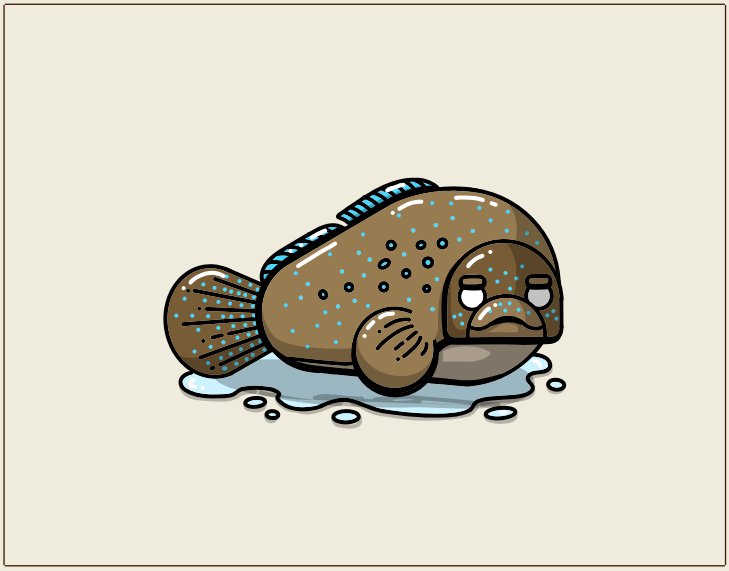
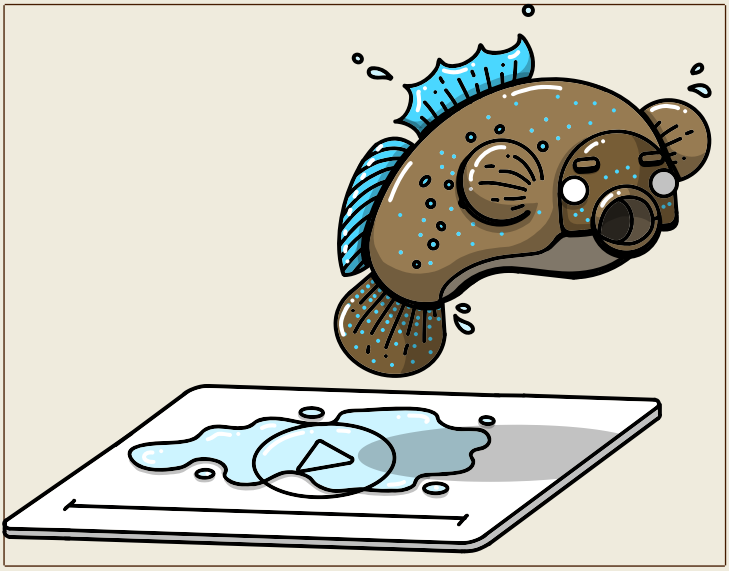


Plate II



THE TUTORIAL SKIPPER

Skippus Impatiens

APPEARANCE

Visible only briefly. If you blink too slowly you will not notice them, as the fins are moving too fast. Recognizable by the speed and decisiveness with which they dismiss any tutorial or tooltip placed in their path. Both eyes sit on the same side of the head, and both are trained on the Skip button.

HABITAT

First-time onboarding flows. Welcome modals. Tooltip tours. The Tutorial Skipper has a particular affinity for any element labeled "Skip," "Maybe later," or the small X in the corner.

FIELD NOTES

The Tutorial Skipper has used many products and is confident this one will not be different. Thus, it believes it definitely does not need the tutorial. The naturalist has frequently seen the same Skipper return, eight minutes later, lost on the exact feature the tutorial was attempting to introduce.

RESOLUTION

A handful of Skippers figure it out by clicking around. Most file a support ticket asking how to do the thing the tutorial would have explained.

HAZARDS OBSERVED

A tutorial that is too long. Tooltips that obscure the interface they're describing. A "Welcome" modal that is the only path into setup.

CONSERVATION STATUS

Common to abundant. Adapts faster than your onboarding does.

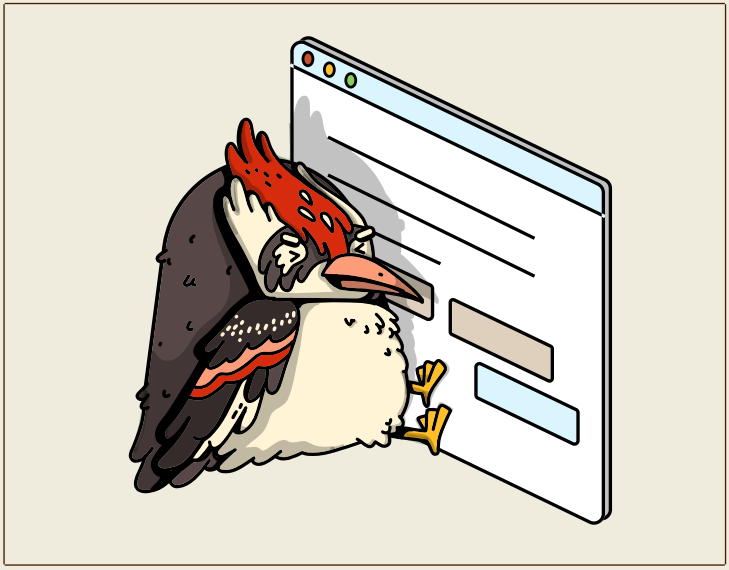
IF YOU SPOT ONE

A high skip rate on onboarding tells you nothing by itself. What matters is whether the Skippers activate anyway, and plenty of them do. A Monitor scanner catches sessions that dismissed onboarding in under five seconds, so save them as a cohort and set it beside your activation numbers. If they activate, your onboarding is optional and you can cut it down. If they do not, you have found the people to win back and the feature to win them back with, since it is the one the tutorial was trying to show them.

Plate I



Plate II



THE MODAL SLAMMER

Closeus immediatus

APPEARANCE

The defining feature is reaction time. The Modal Slammer dismisses any modal in under 400 milliseconds, often before it has finished animating in.

HABITAT

Anywhere your team has placed a modal in the user's path. Cookie banners. Feature announcements. Newsletter prompts especially.

FIELD NOTES

The Modal Slammer does not read the modal. Worse, it rarely even takes the modal into consideration. The naturalist has observed Slammers close, in succession, four overlays in a five-second window.

RESOLUTION

The Slammer continues with their task, slightly more agitated. If the modal mattered, they would discover this later, often in a support ticket asking for the feature it had just announced.

HAZARDS OBSERVED

A modal placed at the worst moment in a flow. A re-onboarding message that fires on every login. A "We've updated our privacy policy" notice that distracts them from the task they wanted to complete.

CONSERVATION STATUS

Abundant. Reflexive. Cannot be reasoned with.

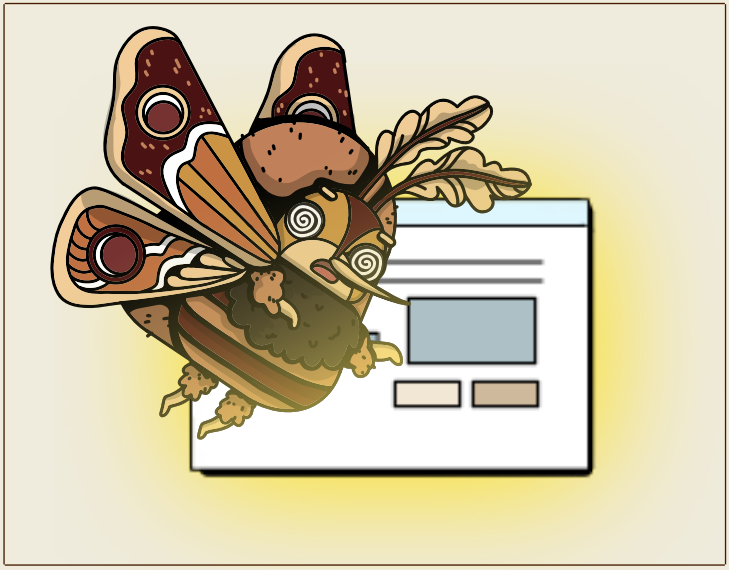
IF YOU SPOT ONE

A modal closed inside a second was never read, so the message is gone either way. The cost that lands is on the task it interrupted. Count the overlays a new user meets before their first real action in your product, because three is common. A Classifier scanner with freeform tags returns a ranked list of what people dismiss without reading. Read it as a list of things you made them close, and cut the one at the top.

Plate I



Plate II



THE PHANTOM RETURNER

Quartum revertus

APPEARANCE

Wing scales dulled and dusty from a long absence, expression carefully neutral. The Phantom Returner moves through your product like someone visiting a house they used to live in, recognizing the rooms but unsure where the furniture has been moved.

HABITAT

Anywhere they used to be familiar, like settings pages renamed, navigation reorganized, features deprecated or relocated. The Returner gravitates toward whatever workflow they remembered most clearly, which is usually the one your team has changed most.

FIELD NOTES

The Phantom Returner has been away for ninety days or more and arrives confident the product looks the same as the morning they left. It does not. Within the first minute, they have encountered three features they cannot locate and one they cannot identify, prompting the small, dignified pause that is the species' signature.

RESOLUTION

Some adapt and quietly resume their workflow, while others give up and assume the product has been ruined since they left. The most vocal minority will send long emails to support that begin with the words "I've been a customer since..."

HAZARDS OBSERVED

Major UI redesigns shipped without changelog visibility. Deprecated features removed without redirects. An empty state where their previous data used to be.

CONSERVATION STATUS

Recurrent but unpredictable. Easily lost.

IF YOU SPOT ONE

After ninety days away, the product moved and the user's memory did not. Settings got renamed, navigation got reorganized, and the feature they used most now lives somewhere else. Try finding your way around your own product using last year's menu names. A Summarizer scanner reading sessions from long-absent users writes down what each one came to do and where they got stuck, and a weekly digest to Slack gives you a standing list of what your dormant customers can no longer find.

Plate I



Plate II



THE DEAD-END WANDERER

Quattuor-zero-quattuor vagus

APPEARANCE

Slightly disoriented. Coat unremarkable, posture defeated. Often arrives at your 404 page via a Google result for a feature you deprecated two years ago.

HABITAT

Broken links. Deprecated routes. Email campaigns pointing to staging URLs. Documentation pages that no longer exist but still rank.

FIELD NOTES

The Dead-End Wanderer was following a link in good faith. The link led here, and now the Wanderer does not know what to do. It reads the 404 page slowly, in case it contains useful information. It does not.

RESOLUTION

Some return to the home page, while others try the search bar. Most get frustrated and close the tab. The naturalist has rarely detected a Dead-End Wanderer reaching its intended destination.

HAZARDS OBSERVED

Outdated marketing copy. Renamed feature URLs without redirects. Email links pointing to environments that no longer exist.

CONSERVATION STATUS

Vulnerable. Mostly silent. Easily neglected.

IF YOU SPOT ONE

Your analytics can count 404s. What they cannot tell you is where the person meant to go, which is the only part you can act on. A good share of broken paths lead back to your own old emails and outdated docs, and those you control. Search your site and your campaigns for links to routes you deprecated. A Classifier scanner asking what the user was trying to reach tags each dead end with its intended destination, and the ranked tags are your most broken paths.

Plate I



Plate II



THE CONSOLE-OPENER

Devtoolus curiosus

APPEARANCE

Indistinguishable from a normal user at first glance, until the moment the keyboard shortcut is pressed. From that point on the skin mottles and darkens, and the eyes acquire focus.

HABITAT

Landing pages of B2B SaaS products. Comparison pages. Documentation that mentions architecture. The Console-Opener has also been observed, less commonly, on the marketing site of their own employer.

FIELD NOTES

The Console-Opener is rarely a casual visitor. The naturalist treats every one as a person of interest as it might be a potential buyer evaluating the product stack. However, it could also be a spy marketer from a competing company. Only the most committed minority go on to file thoughtful bug reports about console errors they noticed.

RESOLUTION

Highly variable. Enthusiastic visitors could become power users, but spy marketers only screenshot your bundle and leave. A few file a polite issue noting that an API key is being leaked in a client-side request.

HAZARDS OBSERVED

Console errors visible to the public. API keys logged in client-side network requests. A 401 returning from an endpoint you forgot was live.

CONSERVATION STATUS

Rare but consequential.

IF YOU SPOT ONE

Someone opening devtools on a marketing page is either evaluating you seriously or has found something you would rather they had not. Open your own landing page console and read it the way a stranger would, watching for leaked keys and 401s from endpoints you forgot were live. Devtools sit outside the page, so the recording never shows them opening. The session's raw events still reach the model, exceptions included. Run a Monitor scanner for sessions that threw a visible error and kept probing instead of leaving.








CLOSING NOTE

The species I have set down here are the ones I have observed often enough, and with sufficient certainty, to risk naming. You will catch more in your own user base.

There are species that have appeared in my notebooks only once or twice, behaviors I have seen which I am not yet ready to call patterns, peculiarities I do not understand. Some of them will turn out to be species in their own right. The work of naming proceeds slowly, even now that the work of watching does not.

Replay Vision, which helped me compile this guide, remains in the field, and does not require my presence to continue. By the time this volume is printed, it will have observed more than I will read in a lifetime.

If the reader has a product of their own, they will find species in it that this guide does not yet describe. I would encourage them, on Hogworth's own authority, to give those species names.

The work, for any reader who wishes to take it up, begins with Replay Vision.

— S.B.H.

FURTHER SIGHTINGS

A field notebook for the reader

Sighting No.1

SPECIES: _____

PROVISIONAL BINOMIAL: _____

DATE OBSERVED: _____

HABITAT: _____

DISPOSITION _____

Sighting No.2

SPECIES: _____

PROVISIONAL BINOMIAL: _____

DATE OBSERVED: _____

HABITAT: _____

DISPOSITION _____

Sighting No.3

SPECIES: _____

PROVISIONAL BINOMIAL: _____

DATE OBSERVED: _____

HABITAT: _____

DISPOSITION _____

Sighting No.4

SPECIES: _____

PROVISIONAL BINOMIAL: _____

DATE OBSERVED: _____

HABITAT: _____

DISPOSITION _____

Recommended companions: a pencil, and a slow afternoon. - S.B.H

FURTHER SIGHTINGS

A field notebook for the reader

Sighting No.5

SPECIES: _____

PROVISIONAL BINOMIAL: _____

DATE OBSERVED: _____

HABITAT: _____

DISPOSITION _____

Sighting No.6

SPECIES: _____

PROVISIONAL BINOMIAL: _____

DATE OBSERVED: _____

HABITAT: _____

DISPOSITION _____

Sighting No.7

SPECIES: _____

PROVISIONAL BINOMIAL: _____

DATE OBSERVED: _____

HABITAT: _____

DISPOSITION _____

Sighting No.8

SPECIES: _____

PROVISIONAL BINOMIAL: _____

DATE OBSERVED: _____

HABITAT: _____

DISPOSITION _____